

8 Tips for Bridging the Gap from Dining Out to Eating In

Though I never had any problems skimping on housing and transportation, my line was drawn on nourishment. It is a huge leap from eating out for many meals as a busy professional to cooking nearly every meal in an established household. Here are my strategies for bridging that gap.

1. Eat lunch out with these caveats: Get a vegetable plate or something reasonably healthful (entrée with two veggies); don't get something that you can fix easily at home such as pizza or spaghetti.
2. Have a light dinner (salad, soup, and/or sandwich) on the days you eat your lunches out. Those are inexpensive to prepare at home and very easy to make. You'll save on your energy bill by cooking and washing dishes less.
3. Eat at home even if you don't cook at home. You'll develop the



habit of taking the time to sit down sometime before 8:00 PM (hopefully) to enjoy a meal. And it's easier to split a large restaurant meal or Chinese takeout at home.

4. Snack before dinner. The snack won't ruin your dinner and it will help you have the energy to cook.
5. Buy high-quality prepared foods from retail caterers; you'll get a home-cooked meal at less than restaurant prices and reinforce the fun of eating at home.
6. Take a cooking class. I took classes at my community college and learned how to wash spinach and cook a roast. My instructor was the expert who could diagnose reasons for cooking failures and offer reasonably priced substitutions for unusual, budget-busting ingredients.
7. Try new recipes on the weekends or days you get home early. If a recipe takes a while (the prep time in cookbooks underestimates time by at least 50%), then you won't be starved come